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Ideas and Individuals

JUST AS HISTORY and geography shape foreign policy, some individuals and their ideas also have a profound impact on how a nation looks at the world outside. During India's long struggle for freedom from British colonial rule, several leaders including Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, Subhas Chandra Bose, Vallabhbhai Patel and Chakravarti Rajagopalachari made pronouncements on international relations. It was the foreign policy views of Jawaharlal Nehru, however, that prevailed over all others. US Secretary of State Dean Acheson considered Nehru critical to India's global role, 'so important to all of us, that if he did not exist – as Voltaire said of God – he would have to be invented'.[1] Most of Nehru's successors held on to his tradition, with minor changes, as a guarantee of India's stability in dealing with the rest of the world.

Nehru was both politician and scholar. Observing him as prime minister, sociologist Edward Shils pointed out: 'Few men so intellectual by disposition, occupy positions in any countries.'[2] Born into an elite Hindu family, Jawaharlal Nehru had been schooled at prestigious British institutions known for training Britain's ruling class: Harrow Public School and Cambridge University. In his own words he returned to India 'perhaps more an Englishman than an Indian' and 'looked upon the world almost